
BAY CURIOUS

Why Is Flock Safety So Controversial in the Bay Area?

Flock Safety technology has been implemented by cities across the Bay Area. Are they here to stay?

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By KQED News Staff









A Flock Safety worker holds up a new Automated License Plate Reader that was being installed in East San Jose on Tuesday, April 23, 2024. (Joseph Geha/KQED)

Flock Safety automated license plate readers have proliferated across the Bay Area over the past several years. But as residents learn more about the type of data captured and how it can be us



Bay Curious
Why Flock License Plate Readers Are So Controversial



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- [San Francisco Police Audit Shows Feds ‘Improperly’ Accessed License Plate Data Hundreds of Times](#)
- [Stanford Cuts Ties With Flock Safety, Shifts to New Surveillance Vendor](#)

Episode Transcript:

Resident after resident came to the mic during public comment ...

Bay Area Resident: Having Flock cameras will not keep us safe. These cameras will go up in the neighborhoods where people of color live and we can be damn sure that this information will

Olivia Allen-Price: Flock is a controversial surveillance company that runs AI-powered license plate readers.

Robert Battinich: I own property in San Leandro and I've been robbed 24 times. Recently, they put Flock cameras in San Leandro, and it seems to be that they haven't been breaking in. So,

Olivia Allen-Price: On one side of the debate: law enforcement and their supporters, who say the cameras reduce crime and improve public safety. On the other: residents and advocates who

Narayan: Good evening. I urge you to reject Flock's \$854,000 contract extension. This isn't a camera system, it's a mass surveillance network. You guys say you care about immigrant communities

Olivia Allen-Price: The budget meeting lasted hours — and in the end, the board of supervisors voted 3-2 in favor of extending the contract. Protests broke out.

[Protesters outside of budget meeting]: Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block!

Olivia Allen-Price: Since that April meeting, the Flock contract was extended in Alameda County again through the end of 2027 to the tune of \$2.4 million. And it's against this backdrop that I

Dennis Riley: I've seen flock cameras all around the city, all around the Bay Area. .. there's really no escape from them. I don't really know what information they record. Um, how much I'm

Olivia Allen-Price: He wants to know what Flock is doing with the information they record...

Dennis Riley: Who are they selling it to? What are they recording? What is this information being used for? It really unsettles me how much I'm being tracked by private companies.

Olivia Allen-Price: To answer this one we turn to Morgan Sung, a tech journalist and the host of KQED's Close All Tabs podcast, who recently took on this topic...

Morgan Sung: Automated license plate readers, or ALPRs, have been rapidly rolled out by cities and communities around the country, with Flock Safety's tech at the lead. Before we get any

Let's get into the origin story. So, Flock Safety is based in Atlanta, Georgia. It operates a whole host of surveillance devices: cameras, drones, and, importantly, for this story, ALPRs. Back in 2016,

So, Garrett called up two of his college buddies. Together, they worked on a prototype camera that could record and share what he called "evidence," not just footage. Here he is speaking to *Forbes*.

[Clip of Garrett's interview with @Forbes on YouTube]: Yeah, it's pretty wild. At the end of '17, we were sitting at my dining room table in Atlanta, building cameras by hand. And now

Morgan Sung: "Fun" is certainly one way to put it. This entrepreneurial, neighborly concern has grown into an operation of at least 90,000 cameras nationwide, scanning over 20 billion license plates

In Oakland, the push for installing Flock's ALPRs was fueled by local frustration over BIP-ing — you know, breaking into a parked car and looting whatever's inside. Here's Roselyn Romero, a

Roselyn Romero: BIP-ing, or car break-ins, were also understandably making a lot of residents angry.

Morgan Sung: The city took action around 2024.

Roselyn Romero: The Oakland Police Department eventually signed a contract with Flock Safety for cameras to be installed throughout the city, primarily on freeway entrances and exits. A

Roselyn Romero: The make and the model of that vehicle, if there is a scrape on the bumper, or if there are bumper stickers on the car — Flock keeps a database of all of that information of

Morgan Sung: Flock will send officers alerts when a camera captures a vehicle that's been marked stolen or wanted. Or, the police can search the database to trace a specific vehicle's movement. But whether Flock has any part in that is dubious. The city started cracking down on car break-ins long before it adopted Flock cameras. Still, supporters say that Flock is necessary to prevent

Roselyn Romero: Flock also has cameras that are called pan, tilt, and zoom cameras. Those cameras, which are currently being used by the Alameda County Sheriff's Office, can be used to track

Morgan Sung: All of the data collected by Flock cameras around the country is shared and stored in a massive aggregated database, which can be accessed by anyone in the network. That means

Both of these scenarios are real. They've already happened. Privacy activists and civil liberties groups are especially worried. Given the Trump administration's recent immigration crackdown.

Roselyn Romero: People are scared — even putting Flock cameras aside, many immigrants are afraid of immigration enforcement knocking on their doors. We're hearing a lot of newly arrived

We've been seeing reports of law enforcement agencies and police departments in places outside of California that have shared data with Border Patrol, with U.S. Customs and Immigration Enforcement

And so a lot of people are understandably afraid. And really concerned about, well, if this technology is continued here in Alameda County, who's to say that that data is gonna end up in the wrong hands?

A big part of the concern is around data privacy. Flock says it deletes all the information after 30 days. But the company isn't very transparent about how they handle all of this data.

Roselyn Romero: There have been a lot of concerns from community members I've interviewed who say, you know, even if this data is stored in this database for 30 days, what happens after that?

Morgan Sung: Flock also says all of this data, and their camera feeds, are encrypted. These assurances fall flat, though. Around the U.S., amateur hackers have been able to get around the encryption

[Clip from @BennJordan on YouTube]: You may remember me from this video, where I told you about 40,000 of these things that your tax dollars pay for that are tracking your every movement

Morgan Sung: With the help of a cybersecurity expert, Benn was able to hack Flock safety cameras in a whopping 30 seconds.

[Clip from @BennJordan on YouTube]: First thing you're going to want to do is go ahead and press the button to turn on that police camera. Then press the button on the back a number of times

Morgan Sung: Apparently, hacking a Flock camera really is that easy. At least, it was when that video was published. And once you're in, there's a lot you can do.

[Clip from @BennJordan on YouTube]: You can clone or decompile the apps. You could send the video stream data to a remote server. You could use it as a botnet client for malware. You could

Roselyn Romero: When these cameras can be hacked and used to spy on people or watch kids, watch everyday people, it really makes you think: how comfortable are we with this type of monitoring?

Morgan Sung: In a follow-up video, Benn showed how easy it was to find the control panels for Flock's cameras. 404 Media confirmed that at least 60 of Flock's Condor cameras — the ones that are used for

So, if Flock cameras can be easily hacked or are left totally unsecured, what does it mean for the troves of data? All the photos, the live feeds, the vehicle fingerprints that are stored on Flock's servers?

Roselyn Romero: There have been a lot of red flags raised by privacy experts and technology experts who say that Flock doesn't have enough data privacy safeguards to protect itself from liability

Morgan Sung: There have been reports of law enforcement using Flock data for both of these purposes — as well as more... personal uses.

Roselyn Romero: We've seen reports from other parts of the country where police officers have used Flock's database to track down their ex-girlfriends and stalk them.

Morgan Sung: A Wisconsin cop used Flock to stalk his ex-girlfriend and her partner. He submitted 179 database searches for their license plates. In fact, multiple officers have been accused

Morgan Sung: And that's all assuming that technology is working correctly. What if Flock's vehicle fingerprint is wrong? Just a few months ago, police stopped a 62-year-old woman in Oakland.

Roselyn Romero: So, she exited the vehicle with her hands up, her car registration was in her hand, and she saw these sheriff's deputies pointing their guns at her — and she was really confused. And so, eventually the sheriff's deputies told her, "Oh, you might not be the suspect we're looking for because the license plate reader tracked down your license plate. And we essentially connect you to the crime."

Morgan Sung: What the woman didn't know was that her plates had been stolen, and replaced with the ones associated with the crime.

Roselyn Romero: She came to the realization, "I'm being treated like I'm a violent criminal." That could have gone so much worse than it did, right?

Morgan Sung: But here's the thing: Flock flagged a black Honda Civic. This woman drove a silver car. Flock's "vehicle fingerprint" is supposed to be holistic, taking into account way more data than just the license plate.

Roselyn Romero: It opens up this scary question of: can this happen to me? Can this happen to someone I love, someone I know — completely unsuspecting — who may have had their license plate stolen?

Morgan Sung: And here's another issue with this technology: racial bias. Black and Brown communities are already more likely to be overpoliced and are disproportionately targeted for traffic stops. And as one study showed, Flock Safety cameras have been found to surveil predominantly Black communities more intensely than white ones. In Virginia's Hampton Roads area, neighborhood cameras are more likely to be in Black neighborhoods.

Roselyn Romero: In neighborhoods where Black and Brown people are already overly policed, overly surveilled, and overly criminalized, these cameras can play a big role in terms of the type of surveillance that's being done.

Morgan Sung: And, the company has been long-resistant to efforts to track and log its devices, like in the case of a project called DeFlock. It's an open-source, community-run tool that identifies vehicles.

[Clip of Garrett's interview with @Forbes on YouTube]: Unfortunately, there's terroristic organizations like DeFlock, whose primary motivation is chaos. They are closer to Antifa than they are to the police.

Morgan Sung: That interview is from September of last year. A few months later, he sent an unsolicited email to all Flock law enforcement clients.

Roselyn Romero: And in that email, the CEO attacked activist groups who were against Flock. He said that they wanted to normalize lawlessness and let murderers go free. The CEO also called them "terrorists."

Morgan Sung: This prompted the city of Staunton, Virginia, as well as several others, to officially terminate their contracts.

Roselyn Romero: And in a press release, the police chief of Staunton, Virginia, basically was like, "We will not tolerate this type of rhetoric." They said, quote, "The city of Staunton wants to maintain a professional relationship with Flock."

Morgan Sung: Langley's comments also came amid intense debate over local police sharing Flock data with ICE, which is a violation of city policy in some places. Altogether, it was a PR disaster.

Despite all the vocal opposition, Flock has a lot of support from businesses looking to improve public safety around their buildings — whether it's private companies trying to protect employees or schools trying to protect students.

Roselyn Romero: Flock Safety cameras have been used by many business leaders and commercial districts throughout the Bay Area to address crime, prevent crime, track down people who are dangerous.

Morgan Sung: But residents are becoming more vocal about their distrust in Flock — in part, because it's unclear who exactly has access to Flock's data once it's collected.

Roselyn Romero: Who's to say that these law enforcement agencies from other states can also use data from California law enforcement agencies?

Morgan Sung: How far is this data being shared? Is Flock breaking local laws? One reporter in Palo Alto uncovered a slew of Flock search requests that violated the city's own policies. We're talking about a city that's been sued for racial discrimination.

Olivia Allen-Price: Stay with us.

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Olivia Allen-Price: One huge concern for advocates is how Flock data is being shared. Reporter and Podcast Host Morgan Sung digs in on a scandal that broke out in Palo Alto.

Riley Cooke: People were just as fired up about a pickleball debate a couple of weeks ago in Palo Alto — so there are certain issues that definitely get people to turn out, whether it's convertir

Morgan Sung: Riley Cooke is a City Hall reporter at Palo Alto Weekly. Earlier this year, a publication in nearby Mountain View had discovered that the city's Flock data had been accessed by

Riley Cooke: So what I did is I filed a records request for these search audits that Flock and the police department maintain. So, every time a search is conducted, whether by a local officer o

Morgan Sung: The request was approved, but at first, the police chief didn't hand over the specific documents that Riley was looking for.

Riley Cooke: So, I reopened the request and said, "Hey, I actually want these spreadsheets." And eventually they gave them to me in March. And my editor was- he was out on some, like, cof

Morgan Sung: The search records revealed that police departments from all over the country were also searching Palo Alto's Flock data, without the permission of the city, or the Palo Alto P

Riley Cooke: The police department told me that they didn't actually access any of the data or download it, but Palo Alto's cameras still appeared in search results from, you know, Mississippi

Morgan Sung: ATF is short for the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms, and Explosives. Riley's reporting shows that, for about a year and a half, tens of thousands of searches from outside

Riley Cooke: I think my hope with doing that was to sort of beg the question of: what do these agencies have anything to do with Palo Alto? Or why is Palo Alto's ALPR data appearing in sea

Morgan Sung: This is actually super illegal. California law prohibits the sharing of ALPR data with out-of-state and federal agencies — and this has been the case since 2016. The Palo Alto P

Riley Cooke: And, they went above and beyond existing California law about not sharing with any out-of-state or federal agencies. And, what my reporting shows is that Flock was still able to

I think city officials were really confident at first that they had enacted these protections, that they were protecting residents and heeding those surveillance concerns. And yet, at the end of the

Morgan Sung: It begs the question: why did Flock bypass the police department and make this data available nationwide? And what is the point of privacy protections if Flock can just acces

Riley Cooke: Recently there's been hundreds of people turning out to city government meetings to protest the Flock contract and urging Palo Alto to do what neighboring cities have done, w

Morgan Sung: Now, thanks to Riley's reporting, the Palo Alto Police Department is proactively sharing license plate search logs on its website.

Riley Cooke: So, everyone's able to go and find that information on their own, and can verify that no out-of-state or illegal searches are being performed. I don't know any other city that's cu

Morgan Sung: The consulting firm in charge of the Flock audit — called the OIR Group — has managed to hold Palo Alto's cops accountable in the past — like standardizing bodycam usage.

Riley Cooke: They don't like that they were lied to. And so, I think a lot of residents had their suspicions about this, couldn't exactly confirm that it was happening in Palo Alto, and my repor

Morgan Sung: Riley said the Palo Alto Police Department will probably listen to resident demands for greater transparency around Flock. But, even if the city gets rid of Flock cameras, law e

We're heading back to Alameda County, where Oakland is partnering with Flock to operate nearly 300 ALPRs throughout the city. But organizers remain committed to protesting the contract

Roselyn Romero: Because of Alameda County's location, situated where all of these technological and AI advancements are originated, and the fact that Alameda County is home to many s

A lot of these social justice movements, racial justice movements, and activists are also on the side of: we shouldn't have Flock in our communities, and why are we continuing to expand these

Morgan Sung: In California, organizers have actually made real progress in stopping Flock — or getting it removed. Santa Cruz was the first city to turn off its cameras. Mountain View, South

Roselyn Romero: In Oakland, we’ve seen people paintbombing these Flock cameras, where cameras in Oakland have just been splashed with paint and vandalized, if you will.

Morgan Sung: And beyond the concerns about Flock’s capabilities, the company’s services are expensive. Flock contracts add up to millions of dollars. And this has many residents questioning

Roselyn Romero: When crime is at near historic lows, why are we continuing to put more money and more power into these powerful technologies? Right now, the Oakland City Council is

A lot of community members are saying, “Why are we continuing to invest in police technologies and surveillance tools when we could instead allocate that money toward, say, health care or c

It’s a really interesting and seemingly endless debate that we’re seeing in Oakland and Alameda County and across the country.

Alameda County Supervisor David Haubert: [bangs gavel] We have to take a vote on this.

Morgan Sung: Back in April, at the Alameda Board of Supervisors meeting, the board voted in favor of extending the Flock contract until July 1st. That’s despite the vocal pushback from res

[Protesters outside of budget meeting]: Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block!

Morgan Sung: Last Tuesday — the day before the contract expired —the Alameda Board of Supervisors once again voted to extend Flock’s contract... This time, until the end of next year.

Alameda County Supervisor David Haubert: So that motion passes. We’re not entertaining comments from the gallery.

Morgan Sung: Once that’s up, the County Sheriff’s Office will have the opportunity to look for alternative vendors: surveillance tech companies that offer the same services as Flock. There are

So, even if the board votes to end its contract, this larger question still exists: Does mass surveillance of people who aren’t suspected of a crime violate their Fourth Amendment right to privacy?

Roselyn Romero: This debate is not unique to the Bay Area. We’re seeing — at the federal level — President Donald Trump’s mass deportation agenda playing out in full force. What does th

Morgan Sung: This debate gets at the heart of the right to privacy, guaranteed by the Constitution, but chipped away at every year. Communities across the country have made it clear that th

Olivia Allen-Price: That was KQED tech journalist Morgan Sung who reported on this for the Close All Tabs podcast, which she hosts. Their team includes Maya Cueva, Chris Egusa, Chris I

Thanks to Dennis Riley, for asking this week’s question.

Bay Curious is produced in SF at member-supported KQED.

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I’m Olivia Allen-Price. Have a great week.

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